

PART FIVE

Knowing God Without Arguments



The selections in the previous section illustrate what has undoubtedly been the most common approach among philosophers in considering the question of the existence of God. Theists marshal the available arguments, do their best to formulate them in the best way possible, and defend them against objections. Atheists, on the other hand, look for flaws and loopholes in the theistic arguments; they also develop arguments against belief in God. (By far the most common argument of this sort is the problem of evil, which is discussed in Part Eight). The debate between the two sides rages on, with no final resolution in sight.

One of the most interesting developments in recent philosophy of religion is the rise of a way of addressing belief in God that circumvents the debate described above. The philosophers who support this approach see no need for arguments proving the existence of God; they may even believe that such arguments are harmful. These philosophers, however, are not fideists (see Part Three, on faith and reason); they are very much concerned that their faith be rationally justified, and they are at pains to defend their belief against the problem of evil and other arguments against theism. Their approach is often referred to as “Reformed epistemology,” because of a certain affinity with the Reformed, or Calvinistic, branch of Christianity. However, one need not be a Calvinist, or even a Christian, to be a Reformed epistemologist.

BASIC AND DERIVED BELIEFS

But how is it possible to rationally defend belief in God, while ignoring the arguments for God’s existence? In order to understand this, there are a few concepts of epistemology (the theory of knowledge) that we need to have in mind. First of all, there is the distinction between *basic beliefs* and *derived beliefs*. A derived belief is a belief that one accepts because it is supported by (and thus derived from) other beliefs that one holds. A detective’s belief about who is guilty of a crime is a derived belief, based on the evidence the detective is aware of. Now, a little thought will suggest that not all of our beliefs can be derived beliefs; this would mean that whatever we

believe is supported by some other belief, which is in turn supported by still another belief, and so on forever. And that does not seem possible. There must be some beliefs of ours, then, that are *basic*, beliefs that do not need to be supported by other beliefs we hold. If during lunch I ask you, "What are you eating?" and you reply that it is a ham sandwich, it doesn't occur to me to ask, "On what do you base that belief?" If I did ask that, you might reply, "What do you mean? It just is a ham sandwich, and I am eating it right now." This is a basic belief, one that doesn't need to be based on anything else you believe. And our basic beliefs are the foundation of all of the other, derived beliefs, so that our entire belief structure ultimately rests on those basic beliefs.

Next, we need the concept of a *properly basic belief*. A properly basic belief is a basic belief such that, given the circumstances in which you hold the belief, it is rationally appropriate—right and proper, we might say—that you hold that belief in a basic way. Your belief about the ham sandwich, at the time when you are eating it, is undoubtedly a properly basic belief. On the other hand, suppose you see a stranger's face on television and immediately say to yourself, "I don't trust that fellow at all." This again expresses a basic belief, but it may well be *improperly* basic; most likely, you cannot reasonably or reliably conclude under those circumstances that the person in question is not trustworthy.

STRONG FOUNDATIONALISM

Now, an important question in the theory of knowledge is: What are the requirements for a belief to be properly basic? What sorts of beliefs is it legitimate to hold in a basic way, so that they do not need to be supported by other beliefs? One approach to this question that has historically been popular can be labeled as *strong foundationalism*. The key idea of strong foundationalism is that the properly basic beliefs are limited to those concerning which it is impossible, or nearly impossible, that we should go wrong. These may include beliefs about one's own immediate experience ("My tooth is hurting me"), simple perceptual beliefs ("This is a ham sandwich"), and "self-evident" truths of logic and mathematics (" $2 + 3 = 5$ "). If we can show how all of our other legitimate beliefs can be based on these "maximally certain" kinds of beliefs, we should be able to erect a belief structure that is very nearly flawless. René Descartes is famous for having set up his own theory of knowledge along these lines, but many other philosophers have made similar attempts. A strong foundationalist will think that belief in God, if it is to be rational, needs to be supported by good arguments, perhaps including some of the arguments discussed in the previous chapter. (It should be clear that a strong foundationalist will also be a *strong rationalist*, of the sort discussed in Part Three of this book.)

Unfortunately, this inspiring project cannot be carried out; it simply is not possible to base all of our knowledge on these few sorts of maximally certain beliefs. One reason for this is that we can't know much of anything without relying heavily on memory. But memory, as all of us realize from time to time, is far from being infallible; to the extent that we rely on it, we have to give up the goal of maximal certainty for our belief system. Yet another problem arises from strong foundationalism itself. Strong foundationalism asserts that *the only propositions that are properly basic are those that concern one's own immediate experience, or are self-evident, or are simple perceptual beliefs*. Now, just try to work out how *that* assertion is supposed to be based on those few kinds of maximally certain beliefs! If you can't do it—and it certainly seems that you can't—then strong foundationalism is *self-refuting*. And unfortunately, that does indeed seem to be the case.

“GOD EXISTS” AS PROPERLY BASIC

But if strong foundationalism is wrong, what *are* the criteria for a belief to be properly basic? It's clear that any reasonable answer to this question will have to be more permissive than the one given by strong foundationalism. And this means that the goal of maximal certainty for our entire belief system will have to be given up. On the other hand, we can't just assume that anything goes—that just anything a person believes can be properly basic. Some sorts of beliefs clearly stand in need of evidential support; the detective who “just knows” who committed a crime but does not have any evidence to support his claim will not stand much of a chance of convincing a jury.

The task of working out a full set of criteria for properly basic beliefs is a challenging one that requires a lot of hard work from epistemologists. At this point, however, the Reformed epistemologists have a radical suggestion to make: why can't the belief that *there is a God* be properly basic? Why can't this be one of the beliefs a person is rationally entitled to hold, even if she has no arguments in support of it and does not base it on any other beliefs that she holds? If this is so, then for such a person the arguments of natural theology are unnecessary and irrelevant—yet she is perfectly rational and justified in her belief that God exists.

Stated thus baldly, the Reformed epistemologist's proposal will strike many people as arbitrary and implausible. *Why* should we suppose that belief in God qualifies as a properly basic belief? Can just *any* belief qualify for that status? If not, then how does belief in God qualify? This is a natural question, but the Reformed epistemologist has an answer for it. When we introduced the idea of a properly basic belief, we said that such a belief is “a basic belief such that, *given the circumstances in which you hold the belief*, it is rationally appropriate . . . that you hold that belief in a basic way.” So when we ask whether the belief in God can be properly basic, we need to consider the circumstances in which that belief is held. Alvin Plantinga (1983) has described some of these circumstances as follows:

There is in us a disposition to believe propositions of the sort *this flower was created by God* or *this vast and intricate universe was created by God* when we contemplate the flower or behold the starry heavens. . . . Upon reading the Bible, one may be impressed with a deep sense that God is speaking to him. Upon having done what I know is cheap, or wrong, or wicked, I may feel guilty in God's sight and form the belief *God disapproves of what I have done*. Upon confession and repentance I may feel forgiven, forming the belief *God forgives me for what I have done*. (“Reason and Belief in God,” p. 80)

Keeping Plantinga's examples in mind, we see that the basic belief in God's existence does not just come out of the blue. The belief has, in a broad sense, *experiential grounds*; the sorts of experiences he described provide the occasion for beliefs concerning God to be formed. But we must be careful to understand this in the right way. It is not a matter of first observing certain characteristics of the flower and then inferring from those characteristics that the flower must have had an “intelligent designer.” That is the way things go when one is employing the teleological argument (discussed in the Part Four), and in that case the belief in God would be a derived belief. In Plantinga's account, however, one simply contemplates the flower and *finds oneself believing* that God created it; there is no inference from one belief to another. Nor does one have a certain sort of experience and infer from that experience that there must be a God who is causing the experience. One has the experience and *finds oneself believing* that God is speaking to one, or is displeased with one, and so on. The resulting beliefs are basic beliefs, not derived beliefs, and they are properly basic in virtue of the circumstances in which the beliefs are formed.

DEFEATERS FOR BASIC BELIEFS

There is one further matter that deserves comment. I said early on that the Reformed epistemologists were very much concerned to defend their belief in God against objections such as the problem of evil. But you might be inclined to ask, "Isn't that unnecessary? If the belief in God is properly basic, as they claim, isn't it 'home free,' so to speak? Why do they have to pay attention to objections?" This, however, would be a misunderstanding. That a belief is properly basic means that one is rational and justified in holding the belief, *other things being equal*. But the fact that a belief is properly basic does not guarantee that the belief is true, because the ways in which these beliefs are formed are not infallible. (Even simple perceptual beliefs can be mistaken: the "ham" in your ham sandwich may really be ham-flavored turkey.) So if there are plausible reasons to think a basic belief is mistaken (that is, if there are "defeaters" for the belief), they need to be considered and, if possible, refuted. And that is how it is for belief in God, according to Reformed epistemology. But that does not mean that one needs to give arguments in favor of the belief itself; in fact, nothing of the sort is called for.

It should be obvious by now that the contentions of the Reformed epistemologists are highly debatable; and, in fact, they have been extensively debated. The selections in this section give you a sampling of some of the questions that have been discussed.

In the first selection, Alvin Plantinga, one of the pioneers of Reformed epistemology, sets out some of the basic concepts of that viewpoint. He also shows the connection between this type of religious epistemology and some traditional themes of Reformed theology; he shows how these ideas account for the sometimes hostile attitude of Reformed theologians to the traditional enterprise of natural theology.

In the next selection, Robert Pargetter considers the Reformed epistemologists' claim that belief in God is properly basic. In particular, he examines several potential defeaters for this claim and considers whether they make belief in God unreasonable. Perhaps the most interesting part of his article, however, is the parallel he draws between the experience of God and the experience of "the Force" in the *Star Wars* film series: the way in which Luke Skywalker and others came to believe in the Force bears an interesting resemblance to the way in which, according to Reformed epistemology, a person may come to believe in God.

In the final selection, William Hasker comments on a debate between Alvin Plantinga and Philip Quinn. The disagreement between Plantinga and Quinn does not concern the existence of God as such: both men are Christian theists. Nor is it over the question of whether religious experience can provide someone with a justification for believing in God that does not depend on inference and argument: they agree that it can. What they disagree about is the strength of the justification enjoyed by the average well-educated contemporary theist, and how this stands up against the defeaters of theistic belief. Quinn holds that, in virtue of the defeaters, most such persons will need the arguments of natural theology to supplement the justification received from experience. Plantinga, however, disagrees; he thinks that most will have no need for natural theology.

Alvin Plantinga

The Reformed Objection to Natural Theology



In this essay, Alvin Plantinga (b. 1932) sets out the essentials of an approach to religious knowledge that has come to be known as Reformed epistemology. Plantinga notes that the tradition of natural theology, which seeks to prove God's existence on the basis of premises that are obvious to any thinking person, has often met with resistance in the Reformed (or Calvinistic) branch of Christianity. Not only have the Reformed Christians felt that the arguments of natural theology are insufficient as a basis for religious belief, but they have considered the whole idea of basing belief on arguments to be misguided. This is not to say, however, that their belief in God is irrational. On the contrary, Reformed Christians have typically held that belief in God is a *properly basic* belief, one that is not held on the basis of any other belief and does not need to be justified in terms of other beliefs—or arguments. In the following piece, Plantinga briefly develops the epistemological position that seeks to make sense of these claims.

Suppose we think of natural theology as the attempt to prove or demonstrate the existence of God. This enterprise has a long and impressive history—a history stretching back to the dawn of Christendom and boasting among its adherents many of the truly great thinkers of the Western world. Chief among these is Thomas Aquinas, whose work, I think, is the natural starting point for Christian philosophical reflection, Protestant as well as Catholic. Here we Protestants must be, in Ralph McInerny's immortal phrase, Peeping Thomists. Recently—since the time of Kant, perhaps—the tradition of natural

theology has not been as overwhelming as it once was: yet it continues to have able defenders both within and without officially Catholic philosophy.¹

Many Christians, however, have been less than totally impressed. In particular Reformed or Calvinist theologians have for the most part taken a dim view of this enterprise. A few Reformed thinkers—B. B. Warfield² for example,—endorse the theistic proofs; but for the most part the Reformed attitude has ranged from indifference, through suspicion and hostility, to outright accusations of blasphemy. And this stance is initially puzzling. It looks a little like the

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attitude some Christians adopt towards faith healing: it can't be done, but even if it could, it shouldn't be. What exactly, or even approximately, do these sons and daughters of the Reformation have against proving the existence of God? What *could* they have against it? What could be less objectionable to any but the most obdurate atheist?

PROOF AND BELIEF IN GOD

Let's begin with the nineteenth-century Dutch theologian Herman Bavinck:

Scripture urges us to behold heaven and earth, birds and flowers and lilies, in order that we may see and recognize God in them. "Lift up your eyes on high, and see who hath created these" Is. 40:26. Scripture does not reason in the abstract. It does not make God the conclusion of a syllogism, leaving it to us whether we think the argument holds or not. But it speaks with authority. Both theologically and religiously it proceeds from God as the starting point.¹

We receive the impression that belief in the existence of God is based entirely upon these proofs. But indeed that would be "a wretched faith, which, before it invokes God, must first prove his existence." The contrary, however, is the truth. . . . Of the existence of self, of the world round about us, of logical and moral laws, etc., we are so deeply convinced because of the indelible impressions which all these things make upon our consciousness that we need no arguments or demonstration. Spontaneously, altogether involuntarily: without any constraint or coercion, we accept that existence. Now the same is true in regard to the existence of God. The so-called proofs are by no means the final grounds of our most certain conviction that God exists: This certainly is established only by faith; i.e., by the spontaneous testimony which forces itself upon us from every side.⁴

According to Bavinck, then, a Christian's belief in the existence of God is not based upon proofs or arguments. By "argument" here, I think he means arguments in the style of natural theology—the sort given by Aquinas and Scotus and later by Descartes, Leibniz, Clarke, and others. And what he means to say, I think, is that Christians don't *need* such arguments. Don't need them for what?

Here I think Bavinck means to hold two things. First, arguments or proofs are not, in general, the source of the believer's confidence in God. Typically, the believer does not believe in God on the basis of arguments; nor does he believe such truths as, for example, that God has created the world on the basis of arguments. Secondly, argument is not needed for *rational justification*; the believer is entirely within his epistemic right in believing that God has created the world, even if he has no argument at all for that conclusion. The believer doesn't need natural theology in order to achieve rationality or epistemic propriety in believing; his belief in God can be perfectly rational even if he knows of no cogent argument, deductive or inductive, for the existence of God—indeed, even if there *isn't* any such argument.

Bavinck has three further points. First he means to add, I think, that we *cannot* come to knowledge of God on the basis of argument; the arguments of natural theology just don't work. (And he follows this passage with a more or less traditional attempt to refute the theistic proofs, including an endorsement of some of Kant's fashionable confusions about the ontological argument.) Secondly, Scripture "proceeds from God as the starting point," and so should the believer. There is nothing by way of proofs or arguments for God's existence in the Bible; that is simply presupposed. The same should be true of the Christian believer then; he should *start* from belief in God, rather than from the premises of some argument whose conclusion is that God exists. What is it that makes those premises a better starting point anyway? And third, Bavinck points out that belief in God relevantly resembles belief in the existence of the self and of the external world—and, we might add, belief in other minds and the past. In none of these areas do we typically *have* proof or arguments, or *need* proofs or arguments.

According to John Calvin, who is as good a Calvinist as any, God has implanted in us all an innate tendency, or *nisus*, or disposition to believe in him:

"There is within the human mind, and indeed by natural instinct, an awareness of divinity." This we take to be beyond controversy. To prevent anyone from taking refuge in the pretense of ignorance, God himself has implanted in all men a certain understanding of his

divine majesty. Ever renewing its memory, he repeatedly sheds fresh drops. Since, therefore, men one and all perceive that there is a God and that he is their Maker, they are condemned by their own testimony because they have failed to honor him and to consecrate their lives to his will. If ignorance of God is to be looked for anywhere, surely one is most likely to find an example of it among the more backward folk and those more remote from civilization. Yet there is, as the eminent pagan says, no nation so barbarous, no people so savage, that they have not a deep-seated conviction that there is a God. So deeply does the common conception occupy the minds of all, so tenaciously does it inhere in the hearts of all! Therefore, since from the beginning of the world there has been no region, no city, in short, no household, that could do without religion, there lies in this a tacit confession of a sense of deity inscribed in the hearts of all.⁵

Indeed, the perversity of the impious, who though they struggle furiously are unable to extricate themselves from the fear of God, is abundant testimony that this conviction, namely, that there is some God, is naturally inborn in all, and is fixed deep within, as it were in the very marrow. . . . From this we conclude that it is not a doctrine that must first be learned in school, but one of which each of us is master from his mother's womb and which nature itself permits no one to forget.⁶

Calvin's claim, then, is that God has created us in such a way that we have a strong propensity or inclination towards belief in him. This tendency has been in part overlaid or suppressed by sin. Were it not for the existence of sin in the world, human beings would believe in God to the same degree and with the same natural spontaneity that we believe in the existence of other persons, an external world, or the past. This is the natural human condition; it is because of our presently unnatural sinful condition that many of us find belief in God difficult or absurd. The fact is, Calvin thinks, one who doesn't believe in God is in an epistemically substandard position—rather like a man who doesn't believe that his wife exists, or thinks she is like a cleverly constructed robot and has no thoughts, feelings, or consciousness.

Although this disposition to believe in God is partially suppressed, it is nonetheless universally present. And it is triggered or actuated by widely realized conditions:

Lest anyone, then, be excluded from access to happiness, he not only sowed in men's minds that seed of religion of which we have spoken, but revealed himself and daily discloses himself in the whole workmanship of the universe. As a consequence, men cannot open their eyes without being compelled to see him.⁷

Like Kant, Calvin is especially impressed in this connection, by the marvelous compages of the starry heavens above:

Even the common folk and the most untutored, who have been taught only by the aid of the eyes, cannot be unaware of the excellence of divine art, for it reveals itself in this innumerable and yet distinct and well-ordered variety of the heavenly host.⁸

And Calvin's claim is that one who accedes to this tendency and in these circumstances accepts the belief that God has created the world—perhaps upon beholding the starry heavens, or the splendid majesty of the mountains, or the intricate, articulate beauty of a tiny flower—is entirely within his epistemic rights in so doing. It isn't that such a person is justified or rational in so believing by virtue of having an implicit argument—some version of the teleological argument, say. No; he doesn't need any argument for justification or rationality. His belief need not be based on any other propositions at all; under these conditions he is perfectly rational in accepting belief in God in the utter absence of any argument, deductive or inductive. Indeed, a person in these conditions, says Calvin, *knows* that God exists, has knowledge of God's existence, apart from any argument at all.

Elsewhere Calvin speaks of "arguments from reason" or rational arguments:

The prophets and apostles do not boast either of their keenness or of anything that obtains credit for them as they speak; nor do they dwell upon rational proofs. Rather, they bring forward God's holy name, that by it the whole world may be brought into obedience to him. Now we ought to see how apparent it is not only by plausible opinion but by dear truth that they do not call upon God's name heedlessly or falsely. If we desire to provide in the best way for our consciences—that they may not be perpetually beset by the instability of doubt or vacillation, and that they may not also boggle at the

smallest quibbles—we ought to seek our conviction, in a higher place than human reasons, judgments, or conjectures, that is, in the secret testimony of the Spirit.⁹

Here the subject for discussion is not belief in the existence of God, but belief that God is the author of the Scriptures; I think it is clear, however, that Calvin would say the same thing about belief in God's existence. The Christian doesn't need natural theology, either as the source of his confidence or to justify his belief. Furthermore, the Christian *ought* not to believe on the basis of argument; if he does, his faith is likely to be unstable and wavering. From Calvin's point of view, believing in the existence of God on the basis of rational argument is like believing in the existence of your spouse on the basis of the analogical argument for other minds—whimsical at best and not at all likely to delight the person concerned.

FOUNDATIONALISM

We could look further into the precise forms taken by the Reformed objection to natural theology; time is short, however; what I shall do instead is tell you what I think underlies these objections, inchoate and unfocused as they are. The reformers mean to say, fundamentally, that belief in God can properly be taken as basic. That is, a person is entirely within his epistemic rights, entirely rational, in believing in God, even if he has no argument for this belief and does not believe it on the basis of any other beliefs he holds. And in taking belief in God as properly basic, the reformers were implicitly rejecting a whole picture or way of looking at knowledge and rational belief; call it *classical foundationalism*. This picture has been enormously popular ever since the days of Plato and Aristotle; it remains the dominant way of thinking about knowledge, justification, belief, faith, and allied topics. Although it has been thus dominant, Reformed theologians and thinkers have, I believe, meant to reject it. What they say here tends to be inchoate and not well-articulated; nevertheless the fact is they meant to reject classical foundationalism. But how shall we characterize the view rejected? The first thing to see is that foundationalism

is a *normative* view. It aims to lay down conditions that must be met by anyone whose system of beliefs is *rational*; and here "rational" is to be understood normatively. According to the foundationalist, there is a right way and a wrong way with respect to belief. People have responsibilities, duties and obligations with respect to their believings just as with respect to their (other) actions. Perhaps this sort of obligation is really a special case of a more general moral obligation; or perhaps, on the other hand, it is *sui generis*. In any event there are such obligations: to conform to them is to be rational and to go against them is to be irrational. To be rational, then, is to exercise one's epistemic powers *properly*—to exercise them in such a way as to go contrary to none of the norms for such exercise.

Foundationalism, therefore, is in part a normative thesis. I think we can understand this thesis more fully if we introduce the idea of a *noetic structure*. A person's noetic structure is the set of propositions he believes together with certain epistemic relations that hold among him and these propositions. Thus some of his beliefs may be *based on* other things he believes; it may be that there are a pair of propositions *A* and *B* such that he believes *A on the basis of B*. Although this relation isn't easy to characterize in a revealing and nontrivial fashion, it is nonetheless familiar. I believe that the word "umbrageous" is spelled u-m-b-r-a-g-e-o-u-s: this belief is based on another belief of mine, the belief that that's how the dictionary says it's spelled. I believe that $72 \times 71 = 5112$. This belief is based upon several other beliefs I hold—such beliefs as that $1 \times 72 = 72$; $7 \times 2 = 14$; $7 \times 7 = 49$; $49 + 1 = 50$; and others. Some of my beliefs, however, I accept but don't accept on the basis of any other beliefs. I believe that $2 + 1 = 3$, for example, and don't believe it on the basis of other propositions. I also believe that I am seated at my desk, and that there is a mild pain in my right knee. These too are basic for me; I don't believe them on the basis of any other propositions.

An account of a person's noetic structure, then, would include a specification of which of his beliefs are basic and which are non-basic. Of course it is abstractly possible that *none* of his beliefs is basic; perhaps he holds just three beliefs, *A*, *B*, and *C*, and

believes each of them on the basis of the other two. We might think this improper or irrational, but that is not to say it couldn't be done. And it is also possible that *all* of his beliefs are basic; perhaps he believes a lot of propositions, but doesn't believe any of them on the basis of any others. In the typical case, however, a noetic structure will include both basic and non-basic beliefs.

Secondly, an account of a noetic structure will include what we might call an index of degree of belief. I hold some of my beliefs much more firmly than others. I believe both that $2 + 1 = 3$ and that London, England, is north of Saskatoon, Saskatchewan; but I believe the former more resolutely than the latter. Here we might make use of the personalist¹⁰ interpretation of probability theory; think of an index of degree of belief as a function $Ps(A)$ from the set of propositions a person S believes or disbelieves into the real numbers between 0 and 1. $Ps(A) = n$, then, records something like the degree to which S believes A , or the strength of his belief that A . $Ps(A) = 1$ proclaims S 's utter and abandoned commitment to A ; $Ps(A) = 0$ records a similar commitment to not- A ; $Ps(A) = .5$ means that S , like Buridan's ass, is suspended in equilibrium between A and not- A . We could then go on to consider whether the personalist is right in holding that a rational noetic structure conforms to the Calculus of Probability.¹¹

Thirdly, a somewhat vaguer notion; an account of S 's noetic structure would include something like an index of *depth of ingression*. Some of my beliefs are, we might say, on the periphery of my noetic structure. I accept them, and may even accept them quite firmly; but if I were to give them up, not much else in my noetic structure would have to change. I believe there are some large boulders on the top of the Grand Teton. If I come to give up this belief, however (say by climbing it and not finding any), that change wouldn't have extensive reverberations throughout the rest of my noetic structure; it could be accommodated with minimal alteration elsewhere. So its depth of ingression into my noetic structure isn't great. On the other hand, if I were to come to believe that there simply is no such thing as the Grand Teton, or no mountains at all, or no such thing as the state of Wyoming, that would have much greater reverberations. And if, *per*

impossible, I were to come to think there hadn't been much of a past (that the world was created just five minutes ago, complete with all its apparent memories and traces of the past), or that there weren't any other persons, that would have even greater reverberations; these beliefs of mine have great depth of ingression into my noetic structure.

Now classical foundationalism is best construed, I think, as a thesis about *rational* noetic structures. A noetic structure is rational if it could be the noetic structure of a person who was completely rational. To be completely rational, as I am here using the term, is not to believe only what is true, or to believe all the logical consequences of what one believes, or to believe all necessary truths with equal firmness, or to be uninfluenced by emotion; it is, instead, to do the right thing with respect to one's believings. As we have seen, the foundationalist holds that there are responsibilities and duties that pertain to believings as well as to actions, or other actions; these responsibilities accrue to us just by virtue of our having the sorts of noetic capabilities we do have. There are norms or standards for beliefs. To criticize a person as irrational, then, is to criticize her for failing to fulfill these duties or responsibilities, or for failing to conform to the relevant norms or standards. From this point of view, a rational person is one whose believings meet the appropriate standards. To draw the ethical analogy, the irrational is the impermissible; the rational is the permissible.

A rational noetic structure, then, is one that could be the noetic structure of a perfectly rational person. And classical foundationalism is, in part, a thesis about such noetic structures. The foundationalist notes, first of all, that some of our beliefs are based upon others. He immediately adds that a belief can't properly be accepted on the basis of just *any* other belief; in a rational noetic structure, A will be accepted on the basis of B only if B *supports* A , or is a member of a set of beliefs that together support A . It isn't clear just what this supports relation is; different foundationalists propose different candidates. One candidate, for example, is *entailment*; A supports B only if B is entailed by A , or perhaps is self-evidently entailed by A , or perhaps follows from A by an argument where each step is a self-evident entailment.

Another and more permissive candidate is probability; perhaps *A* supports *B* if *B* is likely or probable with respect to *A*. And of course there are other candidates.

More important for present purposes, however, is the following claim: in a rational noetic structure, there will be some beliefs that are not based upon others: call these its *foundations*. If every belief in a rational noetic structure were based upon other beliefs, the structure in question would contain infinitely many beliefs. However things may stand for more powerful intellects—angelic intellects, perhaps—human beings aren't capable of believing infinitely many propositions. Among other things, one presumably doesn't believe a proposition one has never heard of, and no one has had time, these busy days, to have heard of infinitely many propositions. So every rational noetic structure has a foundation.

Suppose we say that *weak* foundationalism is the view that (1) every rational noetic structure has a foundation, and (2) in a rational noetic structure, non-basic belief is proportional in strength to support from the foundations. When I say Reformed thinkers have meant to reject foundationalism, I do not mean to say that they intended to reject weak foundationalism. On the contrary; the thought of many of them tends to support or endorse weak foundationalism. What then do they mean to reject? Here we meet a further and fundamental feature of classic varieties of foundationalism: they all lay down certain conditions of proper or rational basicity. From the foundationalist point of view, not just any kind of belief can be found in the foundations of a rational noetic structure; a belief, to be properly basic (i.e., basic in a rational noetic structure) must meet certain conditions.

It is plausible to see Thomas Aquinas, for example, as holding that a proposition is properly basic for a person only if it is self-evident to him (such that his understanding or grasping it is sufficient for his seeing it to be true) or "evident to the senses," as he puts it. By this latter term I think he means to refer to propositions whose truth or falsehood we can determine by looking or listening or employing some other sense—such propositions as

(1) There is a tree before me

(2) I am wearing shoes

and

(3) That tree's leaves are yellow.

Many foundationalists have insisted that propositions basic in a rational noetic structure must be *certain* in some important sense. Thus it is plausible to see Descartes as holding that the foundations of a rational noetic structure don't include such propositions as (1)–(3) but more cautious claims—claims about one's own mental life, for example:

(4) It seems to me that I see a tree

(5) I seem to see something green

or, as Professor Chisholm puts it,

(6) I am appeared greenly to.

Propositions of this latter sort seem to enjoy a kind of immunity from error not enjoyed by those of the former. I could be mistaken in thinking I see a pink rat; perhaps I am hallucinating or the victim of an illusion. But it is at the least very much harder to see that I could be mistaken in believing that I *seem* to see a pink rat, in believing that I am appeared pinkly (or pink ratly) to. Suppose we say that a proposition with respect to which I enjoy this sort of immunity from error is *incorrigible* for me; then perhaps Descartes means to hold that a proposition is properly basic for *S* only if it is either self-evident or incorrigible for *S*.

Aquinas and Descartes, we might say, are *strong* foundationalists; they accept weak foundationalism and add some conditions for proper basicity. Ancient and medieval foundationalists tended to hold that a proposition is properly basic for a person only if it is either self-evident or evident to the senses; modern foundationalists—Descartes, Locke, Leibniz, and the like—tended to hold that a proposition is properly basic for *S* only if either self-evident or incorrigible for *S*. Of course this is a historical generalization and is thus subject to contradiction by scholars, such being the penalty for historical generalization; but perhaps it is worth the risk. And now suppose we say that *classical foundationalism* is the

disjunction of ancient and medieval with modern foundationalism.

THE REFORMED REJECTION OF CLASSICAL FOUNDATIONALISM

These Reformed thinkers, I believe, are best understood as rejecting classical foundationalism.¹² They were inclined to accept weak foundationalism, I think; but they were completely at odds with the idea that the foundations of a rational noetic structure can at most include propositions that are self-evident or evident to the senses or incorrigible. In particular, they were prepared to insist that a rational noetic structure can include belief in God as basic. As Bavinck put it "Scripture . . . does not make God the conclusion of a syllogism, leaving it to us whether we think the argument holds or not. But it speaks with authority." Both theologically and religiously it proceeds from God as the starting point. And of course Bavinck means to say that we must emulate Scripture here.

In the passages I quoted earlier on, Calvin claims the believer doesn't need argument—doesn't need it, among other things, for epistemic respectability. We may understand him as holding, I think, that a rational noetic structure may perfectly well contain belief in God among its foundations. Indeed, he means to go further, and in two separate directions. In the first place, he thinks a Christian *ought* not believe in God on the basis of other propositions; a proper and well-formed Christian noetic structure will *in fact* have belief in God among its foundations. And in the second place Calvin claims that one who takes belief in God as basic can nonetheless know that God exists. Calvin holds that one can *rationaly accept* belief in God as basic; he also claims that one can *know* that God exists even if he has no argument, even if he does not believe on the basis of other propositions. A weak foundationalist is likely to hold that some properly basic beliefs are such that anyone who accepts them, *knows* them. More exactly, he is likely to hold that among the beliefs properly basic for a person *S*, some are such that if *S* accepts them *S* knows them. A weak foundationalist could go on to

say that *other* properly basic beliefs can't be known, if taken as basic, but only rationally believed; and he might think of the existence of God as a case in point. Calvin will have none of this; as he sees it, one needs no arguments to know that God exists.

Among the central contentions of these Reformed thinkers, therefore, are the claims that belief in God is properly basic, and the view that one who takes belief in God as basic can also *know* that God exists.

THE GREAT PUMPKIN OBJECTION

Now I enthusiastically concur in these contentions of Reformed epistemology, and by way of conclusion I want to defend them against a popular objection. It is tempting to raise the following sort of question. If belief in God is properly basic, why can't just any belief be properly basic? Couldn't we say the same for any bizarre aberration we can think of? What about voodoo or astrology? What about the belief that the Great Pumpkin returns every Halloween? Could I properly take *that* as basic? And if I can't, why can I properly take belief in God as basic? Suppose I believe that if I flap my arms with sufficient vigor, I can take off and fly about the room; could I defend myself against the charge of irrationality by claiming this belief is basic? If we say that belief in God is properly basic, won't we be committed to holding that just anything, or nearly anything, can properly be taken as basic, thus throwing wide the gates to irrationalism and superstition?

Certainly not. What might lead one to think the Reformed epistemologist is in this kind of trouble? The fact that he rejects the criteria for proper basicity purveyed by the classical foundationalist? But why should *that* be thought to commit him to such tolerance of irrationality? Consider an analogy. In the palmy days of positivism, the positivists went about confidently wielding their verifiability criterion and declaring meaningless much that was obviously meaningful. Now suppose someone rejected a formulation of that criterion—the one to be found in the second edition of A. J. Ayer's *Language, Truth and Logic*, for example. Would that mean she was committed to holding that

(7) Twas brillig; and the slithy toves did gyre and gymblye in the wabe,

contrary to appearances, makes good sense? Of course not. But then the same goes for the Reformed epistemologist; the fact that he rejects the criteria of classical foundationalism does not mean that he is committed to supposing just anything is properly basic.

But what then is the problem? Is it that the Reformed epistemologist not only rejects those criteria for proper basicity, but seems in no hurry to produce what he takes to be a better substitute? If he has no such criterion, how can he fairly reject belief in the Great Pumpkin as properly basic?

This objection betrays an important misconception. How *do* we rightly arrive at or develop criteria for meaningfulness, or justified belief, or proper basicity? Where do they come from? Must one have such a criterion before one can sensibly make any judgments—positive or negative—about proper basicity? Surely not. Suppose I don't know of a satisfactory substitute for the criteria proposed by classical foundationalism; I am nevertheless entirely within my rights in holding that certain propositions are not properly basic in certain conditions. Some propositions seem self-evident when in fact they are not; that is the lesson of some of the Russell Paradoxes.¹³ Nevertheless it would be irrational to take as basic the denial of a proposition that seems self-evident to you. Similarly, suppose it seems to you that you see a tree; you would then be irrational in taking as basic the proposition that you don't see a tree, or that there aren't any trees. In the same way, even if I don't know of some illuminating criterion of meaning, I can quite properly declare (7) meaningless, even if I don't have a successful substitute for the positivist's verifiability criterion.

And this raises an important question—one Roderick Chisholm has taught us to ask.¹⁴ What is the status of criteria for meaningfulness, or proper basicity, or justified belief? These are typically universal statements. The modern foundationalist's criterion for proper basicity, for example, is doubly universal:

(8) For any proposition *A* and person *S*, *A* is properly basic for *S* if and only if *A* is incorrigible for *S* or self-evident to *S*.

But how does one know a thing like that? Where does it come from? (8) certainly isn't self-evident or just obviously true. But if it isn't, how does one arrive at it? What sorts of arguments would be appropriate? Of course a philosopher might find (8) so appealing that he simply takes it to be true, neither offering argument for it, nor accepting it on the basis of other things he believes. If he does so, however, his noetic structure will be self-referentially incoherent. (8) itself is neither self-evident nor incorrigible; hence in accepting (8) as basic, the classical foundationalist violates the condition of proper basicity he himself lays down in accepting it. On the other hand, perhaps the philosopher has some argument for it from premises that are self-evident; it is exceeding hard to see, however, what such arguments might be like. And until he has produced such arguments, what shall the rest of us do—we who do not find (8) at all obvious or compelling? How could he use (8) to show us that belief in God, for example, is not properly basic? Why should we believe (8), or pay it any attention?

The fact is, I think, that neither (8) nor any other revealing necessary and sufficient condition for proper basicity follows from obviously self-evident premises by obviously acceptable arguments. And hence the proper way to arrive at such a criterion is, broadly speaking, *inductive*. We must assemble examples of beliefs and conditions such that the former are obviously properly basic in the latter, and examples of beliefs and conditions such that the former are obviously not properly basic in the latter. We must then frame hypotheses as to the necessary and sufficient conditions of proper basicity and test these hypotheses by reference to those examples. Under the right conditions, for example, it is clearly rational to believe that you see a human person before you: a being who has thoughts and feelings, who knows and believes things, who makes decisions and acts. It is clear, furthermore, that you are under no obligation to reason to this belief from others you hold; under those conditions that belief is properly basic for you. But then (8) must be mistaken; the belief in question, under those circumstances, is properly basic, though neither self-evident nor incorrigible for you. Similarly, you may seem to remember

that you had breakfast this morning, and perhaps you know of no reason to suppose your memory is playing you tricks. If so, you are entirely justified in taking that belief as basic. Of course it isn't properly basic on the criteria offered by classical foundationalists; but that fact counts not against you but against those criteria.

Accordingly, criteria for proper basicity must be reached from below rather than above; they should not be presented as *obiter dicta*, but argued to and tested by a relevant set of examples. But there is no reason to assume, in advance, that everyone will agree on the examples. The Christian will of course suppose that belief in God is entirely proper and rational; if he doesn't accept this belief on the basis of other propositions, he will conclude that it is basic for him and quite properly so. Followers of Bertrand Russell and Madalyn Murray O'Hair may disagree; but how is that relevant? Must my criteria, or those of the Christian community, conform to their examples? Surely not. The Christian community is responsible to its set of examples, not to theirs.

Accordingly, the Reformed epistemologist can properly hold that belief in the Great Pumpkin is not properly basic, even though he holds that belief in God is properly basic and even if he has no full-fledged

criterion of proper basicity. Of course he is committed to supposing that there is a relevant *difference* between belief in God and belief in the Great Pumpkin, if he holds that the former but not the latter is properly basic. But this should be no great embarrassment; there are plenty of candidates. Thus the Reformed epistemologist may concur with Calvin in holding that God has implanted in us a natural tendency to see his hand in the world around us; the same cannot be said for the Great Pumpkin, there being no Great Pumpkin and no natural tendency to accept beliefs about the Great Pumpkin.

By way of conclusion then, the Reformed objection to natural theology, unformed and inchoate as it is, may best be seen as a rejection of classical foundationalism. As the Reformed thinker sees things, being self-evident, or incorrigible, or evident to the senses is not a necessary condition of proper basicity. He goes on to add that belief in God is properly basic. He is not thereby committed, even in the absence of a general criterion of proper basicity, to suppose that just any or nearly any belief—belief in the Great Pumpkin, for example—is properly basic. Like everyone should, he begins with examples; and he may take belief in the Great Pumpkin as a paradigm of irrational basic belief.

NOTES

1. See, for example, James Ross, *Philosophical Theology* (Indianapolis, Ind.: Bobbs-Merrill, 1969), and Richard Swinburne, *The Existence of God* (Oxford, England: Clarendon Press, 1979).
2. "God," in *Studies in Theology* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1932), pp. 110–111.
3. *The Doctrine of God*, trans. William Hendriksen (Grand Rapids, Mich.: William B. Eerdmans, 1951). This is a translation of vol. 2 of Bavinck's *Gereformeerde Dogmatiek* (Kampen, the Netherlands: Kok, 1918), p. 76.
4. *Ibid.*, p. 78.
5. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. J. T. McNeill and trans. Ford Lewis Battles (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1960), Book I, Chap. iii, sec. 1.
6. *Institutes*, I, iii, 3.
7. *Institutes*, V, v, 1.
8. *Institutes*, V, v, 2.
9. *Institutes*, I, vii, 4.
10. See, for example, Richard Jeffrey's *The Logic of Decision* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1965).
11. See my paper "The Probabilistic Argument from Evil," *Philosophical Studies* 30 (1979): 21.
12. Here I think they were entirely correct; both ancient and modern foundationalism are self-referentially incoherent. See my paper "Is Belief in God Rational?" [*Rationality and Religious Belief*, ed. C. Delany (South Bend, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 1979)], p. 26.

13. "Is Belief in God Rational?" p. 22.
14. *The Problem of the Criterion* (Milwaukee, Wis.: Marquette University Press, 1973).

STUDY QUESTIONS

1. Discuss briefly the reasons why thinkers in the Reformed tradition have tended to dismiss natural theology.
2. What is a basic belief? What is a derived belief? What is a properly basic belief?
3. What is classical foundationalism? Explain briefly Plantinga's objections to classical foundationalism as a theory of knowledge.
4. Plantinga's main contention is that religious beliefs, specifically belief in God, can be properly basic. Why does he think so? Do you find this contention to be plausible?
5. Explain briefly the "Great Pumpkin objection" to the claim that religious beliefs can be properly basic. Do you find the objection to be a serious problem for Reformed epistemology? Why or why not?